

ANALYSIS

Yankees' Aaron Boone keeps saying offense will improve. But when?



The New York Yankees' bats couldn't make a gem from starter Cam Schlichter hold up in Sunday's extra-inning loss to the Braves. Jim McIsaac / Getty Images



By **Brendan Kuty**

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NEW YORK — New York Yankees manager Aaron Boone keeps insisting his team's lineup will turn things around.

A week after the trade deadline, and after another weak performance Sunday in a 2-1 loss in 10 innings to the Atlanta Braves, it hasn't happened yet, and it's now a

question of whether it actually will.

“We have a chance to be a really good club here at the most important time,” Boone said. “But we also know that we’ve got to improve offensively to be that complete team.”

The Yankees’ clubhouse was pin-drop quiet late Sunday afternoon after Michael Harris II’s ground-ball single to right field scored automatic runner Ha-Seong Kim for the eventual game-winning run. The Yankees ended the game by going down in order in the inning’s bottom half, culminating with Ryan McMahon striking out swinging against Tyler Kinley and flinging his bat in disgust.

The near silence reflected the Yankees’ production. Only center fielder Trent Grisham crossed the plate, clubbing a home run with two outs in the eighth inning. It tied the score at 1 and came after the only blemish against Yankees starting pitcher Cam Schlichter — a Matt Olson solo home run in the seventh.

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Otherwise, it was the same old story for the Yankees, who received excellent starting pitching but the equivalent of a whoopee cushion noise from their bats. Schlittler went seven innings, striking out 11 and walking none. It was a performance that begged for some sign of life from the offense.

Instead, the two bats the Yankees acquired at the trade deadline — Heliot Ramos and first baseman Luis García Jr. — combined to go hitless in eight at-bats with three strikeouts. Ben Rice's slide also continued as he went 0-for-4 after entering the afternoon hitting .091 (2-for-22) in seven games in August.

The Yankees have scored just 12 runs in five games since Tuesday, the day after the trade deadline, when they finally had Ramos and García in the same lineup.

Meanwhile, Yankees pitchers' backs are probably hurting from carrying the team. The starters have allowed two runs or fewer in 10 of their last 12 starts. Yankees pitchers also rank first in team ERA at 3.30, ahead of the second-place Milwaukee Brewers (3.47). The Yankees have posted an 88 wRC+ since Aaron Judge (right rib stress fracture) last played May 31 — the worst mark in the majors.

“These guys are doing an incredible job keeping us close in these games,” catcher Austin Wells said. “Just trying to find stuff at the plate. Trying to move guys over and get jobs done. I feel like we’ve done a pretty good job up and down of having great at-bats. We’re just not getting results.”

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One of the Yankees’ many offensive lowlights came in the ninth with two outs. Jazz Chisholm Jr. watched two fastballs down the middle and then swung over a 1-2 changeup from Braves reliever Raisel Iglesias. Chisholm had one of the Yankees’ four hits, and he walked, but he’s hitting a career-worst .216 and isn’t making much progress.

“It’s super frustrating,” Chisholm said. “You know your abilities, and you go out there, and you go in the cage and work every day, and it’s not just coming together in the game. I’ve just got to keep on going and push through it.”

Added Boone, “I think all year (Chisholm is) just struggling to get really dialed in. He’s never had that real hot streak, which he’s certainly capable of, and we’ve seen over the last couple of years where it’s two, three or four weeks of impactful damage, speed and getting on (base) and things like that.”

Another lowlight? When Ramos struck out swinging with runners on second and third and the score tied at 0 to end the sixth. The Yankees went 0-for-6 with runners in scoring position.

The Yankees rightfully will point to a series win in which they took two of three games from the National League East leaders. But they will go into Monday's off day with an offense that's improved on paper but not so much in the box score.

"We're a little more different than we were last week," Boone said. "We do have a little more flexibility personnel-wise, in different days. We have a couple of more real hitters in the lineup. So I feel like we're better right now, even today. Better at-bats than we've had where we've had stretches where we're not getting on base a lot, and we're not getting big hits when we do get those opportunities. So, today, I felt like we were at least hitting the ball off the barrel a lot more. That's baseball. Sometimes you don't get rewarded."

Though the Yankees' lineup has a fresher look, Boone presented the same refrains he relied on before the trade deadline, emphasizing his belief in the bats.

"Hopefully we continue to get a little more healthy as we go and become that team," he said.

The Yankees think starting pitcher Carlos Rodón (elbow inflammation) could return within the next two weeks. Left fielder Cody Bellinger (left hamstring strain) has been running and could be back in a few weeks. The team hasn't offered timetables on Giancarlo Stanton (right calf strain) or Judge.

It might be quite some time before the Yankees find the team-wide health Boone spoke of.

Until then, Boone likely will continue to profess his belief the Yankees' lineup will get better, but without much to back him up.

Brendan Kutny is a Staff Writer for The Athletic covering the New York Yankees and MLB. He has covered the Yankees since 2014, most recently as a beat reporter for NJ Advance Media. Brendan was honored to receive the 2022 New Jersey Sportswriter of the Year award from the National Sports Media Association. He attended William Paterson University and the County College of Morris, and he is from Hopatcong, N.J.

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